

Committee: Human Rights Council

Topic: Restoring International Human Rights Standards After Pandemic-Related Displacement and the Morality of Survival in the Modern World

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Introduction

Pandemics are known to cause global health crises, however they also have a great effect on displacement of people. While usually they don't serve as a direct cause for displacement, they often intensify the underlying social, political and economic drivers of displacement, and exacerbate the human rights challenges faced by the displaced populations. In an environment where people may already face struggles to have their basic human needs met, health crises further expose the vulnerabilities in our human rights systems. A recent example could be how the COVID-19 pandemic has affected internally displaced populations in countries such as Mali, Cameroon, and Somalia, where people that already had to face the effects of the conflicts that caused them to flee, now had to deal with the health crisis. Often, due to the restrictions that are implemented for public safety and prevention of the disease spread, for instance quarantine, the displaced communities, having already limited access to clean water and sanitation, let alone shelter, where they often have to be placed in overcrowded centers, could begin have even more limited access to basic resources, aid and help services. At the end of 2025, it was estimated that there are 82.2 million IDPs (people who are living in internal displacement worldwide) across the globe, and at least 117.8 million people were forcibly displaced due to persecution, conflict, violence, or human rights violations. Furthermore, at the moment there are 219 different types of known viruses that are able to infect humans, with the possibility of substantial pool of millions of other undiscovered virus types. Whereas the COVID-19 has demonstrated how public health emergencies can create and place an additional pressure on already vulnerable and displaced populations. Therefore, it is crucial to consider how the human rights standards could

be restored and reinforced in situations of pandemics outbreaks, when survival is frequently treated as an exception to morality, rather than universal entitlement.

Key Words

Pandemic - an epidemic that occurs worldwide, that affects a large population and involves many countries.

Pandemic displacement - displacement caused by direct or indirect consequences of global epidemics, including economic disruption, loss of housing, conflict-related pressures or restrictions on movement.

Epidemic - rapid increase in cases of disease or medical condition in a specific community, population, or geographical area.

IDP (Internally Displaced Person) - someone that is forced to flee their home that stays within the borders of their own country.

DP (Displaced Person) - a person that is forced to leave their home or habitual residence as a result of violence, conflict, human rights violations or disasters.

Refugee - a displaced person that has crossed an international border to seek safety in a different country, while meeting the conditions for refugee status under international refugee law, including having a well-founded fear of persecution or specific reasons.

International Human Rights System - International laws and institutions created for protection of people's basic human rights.

The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR) - Adopted by the UN General assembly in 1948, UDHR is a foundational global statement of freedoms and rights that belong to every person because they are human.

General Overview

During pandemics, what often happens is countries getting quarantined, they impose border closure and internal lockdowns. This in turn may lead to people getting stranded in transit countries, at borders, airports, and ships, commonly without access to income, shelter or consular support. Furthermore, regulations around traveling could lead to challenges with bringing help or support for refugee camps, which often already are in need of more staff and/or resources. Moreover, internal lockdowns and restrictions can also increase economic insecurity, especially for lower class populations by being at risk of being internally displaced, due to limiting their sources of income, where as a result, they may lose their house and have limited access to food, water, and hygiene resources. When people are put in these situations, meeting the safety requirements against health crises becomes extremely challenging, becoming an

additional problem to the pile of dozens of others. This may lead to health, economic, and human rights crises as well as social unrest.

In places of conflict, political tensions, or violence, spread of epidemics could aggravate the human rights issues and displacement that were already at place. Due to border lockdowns, IDPs could get stuck in dangerous environments, with fewer opportunities to seek safety. What also often happens is people having to leave overcrowded camps, informal settlements, or detention facilities out of fear of getting infected, which can put them at even more risk with fewer access to food, water and sanitation. Besides, the overcrowding of camps already indicates how limited the services available at those camps, because of difficulty to allocate enough resources and enough staff to take care of everyone within those camps and centers.

Such health crises may shine light upon the dilemma of prioritizing citizens over non-citizens in countries that contain refugees and DPs. Neglecting the home population wouldn't be right, but ignoring the needs of people that have nowhere to go or no access to basic necessities would be likewise inhumane. That is why the Universal Declaration of Human rights helps recognize that in dire situations like pandemics, everyone's dignity and human rights must be protected, as everyone must have a right to life, liberty and security.

As a pandemic starts to spiral out of control, it's important for governments and international organizations to as well focus on restoring basic rights and services for displaced people. These can include reopening access to healthcare and education, helping people replace important documents they may have lost, and in general making it easier for people to find housing and employment. At the same time, it's necessary to protect displaced people from the discrimination. Therefore, the aim of the recovery should not only focus on the health crisis, but also on helping affected people to return to a more stable life and regain access to their basic rights.

Major Parties Involved

WHO (World Health Organization) - responsible for coordinating responses to global health crises, international public health, and health governance.

IOM (International Organization for Migration) - leading UN agency in the field of migration.

UNHCR (UN High Commissioner for Refugees) - UN group responsible for refugees and Displaced persons.

Host states - countries that provide a base for external entities, such as refugees.

OHCHR (The Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights) - Leading UN department that promotes and protects human rights globally.

Timeline of Relevant Events

Year	Event
1948	Adoption of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, establishing a global framework for dignity, equality and basic rights.
1951	Adoption of the Refugee Convention, creating an international framework for refugee protection.
2005	Adoption of the revised International Health Regulations, establishing international rules for responding to public health emergencies.
2014-2016	Ebola outbreak in West Africa.
2015-2016	Zika virus outbreak.
2018	Adoption of the Global Compact on Refugees, reinforcing the principles of support for host-communities, as well as responsibility sharing.
2020	COVID-19 declared as pandemic.

Relevant Documents

[Universal Declaration of Human Rights](#) : International Human Rights Declaration

The Foundation of Human Rights Protection

[Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees](#) : The International Refugee Protection Treaty

Foundation for the refugee rights

[The 1951 Convention and 1967 Protocol relating to the Status of Refugees](#) : The 1967 protocol

Continuation of the 1951 Refugee Convention

[International Health Regulations](#) : The International Health Regulations

Provides framework for responding to public health emergencies

[Guiding Principles on Internal Displacement](#) : Presented to Commission on Human Rights in 1998

States rights of internally displaced persons and governmental and authorial obligations before, during, and after displacement.

Possible Solutions

1. *Develop a rights based pandemic emergency framework*

The development of this framework would require implementing public health measures that protect public health, while remaining consistent with international human rights and refugee laws. Any emergency measures that affect displaced people would meet clear and legal standards.

2. *International responsibility-sharing and funding*

This can mean providing financial support for countries hosting large displaced populations. Improvement of emergency funds for healthcare, shelter, food, water, and education. Moreover, provision of debt relief or development assistance to countries whose systems are put under pressure.

3. *Monitoring mechanism*

This may include regular reporting by states regarding the pandemic related restrictions in times of global epidemic outbreaks as well as independent monitoring by OHCHR. Furthermore, this could include complaint systems for displaced people, to know the gaps in the established frameworks for helping the DPs. Finally, this should include reviewing the emergency measures after the pandemics, to see the vulnerabilities of frameworks and systems during their implementation.

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